

Boatloads watch the 'Ganga aarti' in Varanasi

REUTERS

Religious travel accounted for 48 per cent of all domestic overnight trips in the past year, according to the Domestic Tourism Expenditure Survey (DTES) 2025-2026. This shows how travel for pilgrimages have indeed become one of the fastest-growing segments of India's travel and tourism industry.

Historically, pilgrimages were considered acts of penance rather than leisure trips, says Rajiv Mehra, general secretary, Federation of Associations in Indian Tourism & Hospitality (FAITH). Spending tended to be low despite the high footfalls in religious sites. "The organised sector abstained from religious towns, but that has undergone a drastic metamorphosis," he says. High-value bookings are growing at such cities, finds data from MakeMyTrip's *Pilgrimage Travel Trends* 2025. Though 71 per cent of bookings are still for rooms priced below Rs 4,500 a night, in FY24-25, bookings in the Rs 7,000-10,000 range grew by 24 per cent.

A qualitative shift accompanies that: travellers are combining faith with leisure. While 52 per cent of the total holiday package bookings on MakeMyTrip were to religious sites in FY 2024-25, 48 per cent were made by travellers seeking religion with leisure. Thus, services around wellness, heritage walks and walking tours are being offered in towns like Varanasi, Puri, Ayodhya, Rishikesh and Ujjain.

The calendar is packed too. Earlier, pilgrimages to religious places would intensify around events like the Kumbh Mela. Today, there is a year-long travel economy. Take Mata Vaishno Devi. Even in September, when there were landslides, the shrine recorded 185,000 lakh pilgrims, suggesting a year-round flow, with the peak in summer.

The profile of the spiritual traveller is changing too, in surprising ways. According to online bus ticketing platform redBus, Gen Z and young travellers accounted for 53 per cent of spiritual travel bookings during FY26. Popular routes included Bengaluru-Tirupati, Hyderabad-Tirupati, Delhi-Rishikesh, Pune-Nanded, Chennai-Thanjavur and Indore-Ujjain.

New infrastructure helps. The Maharishi Valmiki International Airport and a renovated Ayodhya Dham railway station have helped support the sharp rise in tourists in Ayodhya since the inauguration of the Ram temple. This increasing demand now needs to be translated into tourism circuits, turning pilgrimages into two- to four-day stays, says Mehra of FAITH. That's what will scale up the economics. According to the DTES, religious travel still yielded the lowest average expenditure among the four purposes covered (holidaying, leisure and recreation, health & medical, shopping and pilgrimage & religious), at around Rs 7,694 per trip on average. This can be changed by developing entire hybrid tourism circuits around spiritual centres across India.

This needs big picture planning. Though the Centre has initiated the Pilgrimage Rejuvenation and Spiritual, Heritage Augmentation Drive (PRASHAD) scheme, under which state governments get financial assistance to develop tourism infrastructure at pilgrimage sites, its impact has yet to be felt.

Adil Zaidi, partner, economic development advisory, strategy and transactions, EY India, says that challenges in pilgrim towns, like congestion, inadequate toilets, insufficient public transport, unregulated accommodation and pressure on water resources, need to be addressed. "Pilgrimage destinations should be managed as living urban systems. Capacity must be planned around peak-day and peak-hour demand, not annual footfalls alone," he says. ■

—Sonal Khetarpal



"Spending on pilgri-mages was very low for long, leading to the organised sector ignoring religious towns. The scene has changed drastically"

— RAJIV MEHRA, *General Secretary, Federation of Associations in Indian Tourism & Hospitality* (FAITH)



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Partner, Economic Development Advisory, Strategy and Transactions, EY India

THE SHORTCOMINGS

- Pilgrim towns like Ayodhya attract all-year-round footfalls, but offer visitors limited things
- Among overnight trips, pilgrimage has the lowest average expense, says the DTES
- Pilgrim towns are congested, with scant transport and toilets as well as unregulated lodging

THE SOLUTIONS

- Religious places must lie in 2-4-day circuits linking heritage sites and local experiences
- Tying one big site to smaller spiritual centres will increase stays, benefit entire region
- Actual peak-day demand must be taken into account and plans made for upgrades